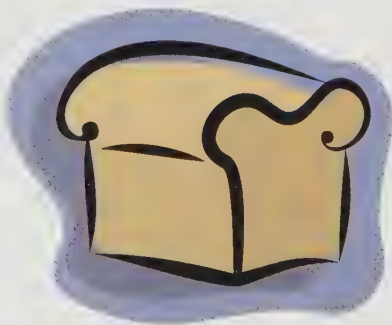


Buy supplies in bulk. Get the largest flour bag and yeast package you can find. (Check your warehouse stores for deals.)

Package your mixes ahead of time. My mom and I had a marathon event of packaging up do-ahead baggies with all the dry ingredients. We even used up all of those dried potato flakes I had hanging around in some delicious potato bread recipes.

Plan bread making into your week. It takes no time at all to dump in the ingredients and push the button; you just have to plan for it. Most bread machines have a delay option to bake while you are at work. Use this to have a nice hot loaf waiting when you get home, and plan a meal around it!



Purchase tip: Bread makers are cluttering up secondhand stores and consignment shops across the country. Take one home for cheap, and search for the user's manual online. Snag one off eBay.com or check CraigsList.org. If you're determined to buy one new,

do some comparison shopping online to get the absolute best deal.

2. The slow-cooker (Crock-Pot)

Nearly everyone I know calls their slow-cooker a "Crock-Pot," even though that name is actually one of many brands that make them. Regardless of whether you go brand-name or not, the final product is a savory way to enjoy lower-quality meats and vegetables. Go ahead and buy that tough discounted roast from the meat department—no one will be the wiser. Tips that can help you maximize savings and give you additional ideas for using the cooker include:

Get some inspiration. I visit A Year of Slow Cooking (AYearOfSlowCooking.com) regularly. The author is brutally honest about which recipes work, and the full-color photos will make you wish it didn't take 6–8 hours to reach that final product.

Plan, plan, plan. 4:30 PM is too late to decide you want to slow-cook some ribs. If you don't have it in mind at the beginning of your day, Crock-Pot cooking will not be an option for your dinner plans.

Think outside the box. Yes, you can cook just about everything in your slow-cooker, including dog food. Some home-decorating enthusiasts